

“QUINCTILIUS VARUS, GIVE ME BACK MY LEGIONS.”

Emperor Augustus, on hearing of the Roman defeat in the Teutoburg Forest, 9 CE

WANG MANG WAS IN CHARGE OF BOTH THE CHINESE ARMY and the government under **Emperor Ping Di** (r. 1 BCE–6 CE). He strengthened his influence by marrying his daughter to the young emperor. On Ping Di's death, many of the

28 THE NUMBER OF DIFFERENT TYPES OF COIN ISSUED BY WANG MANG

nobility rejected Wang Mang's choice of successor and rose up in **revolt**. Wang Mang easily put them down, and in 9 he took the title of **first Xin emperor**. He reissued the currency, forbade the selling of private slaves, reorganized the commanderies

(China's administrative regions), and reimposed several state monopolies. Serious floods on the Yellow River in 4–11 led to **famine and revolts** in rural areas. In 23, the peasant rebels called the “**Red Eyebrows**” joined forces with Han loyalists and overwhelmed Wang Mang's armies. When the capital Chang'an fell, **Gengshi** became the first emperor of the **restored Han dynasty**. One of his first acts was to make Luoyang his capital.

In Europe, **Tiberius** (see 20–2 BCE) returned to Germany in 4 to subdue the tribes there. The **Marcomanni resisted**, but a planned attack on them in 6 was postponed because of a revolt in Pannonia, which took three years to quell. A new Roman commander, **Quintilius Varus**, was sent to Germany, but his **corrupt rule** angered the German tribes. In 9, Varus was ambushed in the **Teutoburg Forest**, and his three legions were annihilated. Augustus then ordered a **withdrawal to the Rhine**, where the Roman frontier remained for the next 400 years.

Consolidating ruler
Rather than extending Roman territory through foreign conquests, Tiberius concentrated on strengthening the existing empire.

When Emperor Augustus (see 20–2 BCE) died in 14, **Tiberius** was his obvious heir (Lucius and Gaius Caesar having died). Tiberius already possessed most of Augustus's powers and had the **loyalty of the Praetorian Guard**—the elite army unit based in Rome, which Augustus had established. Although there were moves in the senate to **restore the Republic**, Tiberius rapidly squashed them. His reign (to 37) was quiet at home. **Germanicus**, Tiberius's nephew, campaigned extensively in Germany up to 16, but his efforts led to no permanent reacquisition of territory beyond the Rhine and he died of poisoning in 19. After Drusus, Tiberius's son, died in 23, the **emperor tired of public life** and retired to the island of Capri, off Naples. **Sejanus**, head of the Praetorian



Guard, took day-to-day power, but his rule was tyrannical and in 31 Tiberius suddenly reasserted himself and had Sejanus executed.

Ponte di Tiberio, Rimini, Italy
Completed in the reign of Tiberius, this bridge carried the Via Aemilia (which ran from Rimini to Piacenza) across the Marecchia River.



GENGSHI'S REIGN AS CHINESE EMPEROR WAS SHORT. He alienated the Red Eyebrows and angered many of China's nobility and bureaucrats by moving the capital from Luoyang back to **Chang'an**. Much of China had already slipped from Gengshi's grasp by 25, when Chang'an was sacked by the Red Eyebrows. The emperor was deposed and replaced by **Guang Wudi** (25–57), who is regarded as the first **Eastern Han** emperor. The new ruler had first to face a **civil war**; by 27, he had defeated the Red Eyebrows, but it took him until 36 to overcome the last of the **warlords** who opposed him. In 37, he abolished all except three of the kingdoms that had sprung up



KEY
 ■ Qin China in 206BCE
 ■ Territory added by Former Han Dynasty 206BCE–9CE
 — Great Wall under the Han

Chinese Han Empire
When Guang Wudi began the Eastern Han Dynasty in 25, Chinese control extended deep into Central Asia. Much of this territory had been won under the Western Han Dynasty.

